Parashat Chayei Sara — The Story in Plain Words

Sarah dies at the age of one hundred and twenty-seven, and Abraham mourns her. He buys a field with a cave — the cave of Machpelah, near Hebron — from Ephron the Hittite, paying four hundred shekels of silver in full, in front of witnesses. There he buries Sarah. It is the first piece of the promised land that Abraham owns.

Now Abraham is old, and Isaac still has no wife. Abraham sends his trusted servant back to his homeland to find a wife for Isaac from his own family — never from the Canaanites around them. The servant worries: what if no woman will come? Abraham answers that God will send an angel before him.

At a well in the evening, the servant prays for a sign: let the young woman who offers him a drink — and offers to water his camels too — be the one. Before he finishes praying, Rebekah arrives with her jar, draws water, and says exactly those words. She waters ten camels. The servant knows his prayer was answered.

He tells Rebekah's family the whole story, gives her gold, and asks for her hand for Isaac. Her family agrees, and Rebekah herself agrees to go. She rides back with the servant, meets Isaac in the field at evening, and becomes his wife — and Isaac is comforted after his mother's death.

The portion closes with Abraham's last years: more children, gifts for them, and his death at one hundred and seventy-five. Isaac and Ishmael bury him beside Sarah in the cave of Machpelah. Then the story turns to Ishmael's twelve sons — and the next chapter of the family begins.